MASTER GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT

(Working title)
Studio: Mallard Industries (pixel-art mallard logo).
Last batch update: October 22, 2026

PURPOSE

This is the canonical source of truth for the game's design. Once a decision is established in discussion, it is transferred here and treated as FIRM — to be changed only by deliberate edit, not casual revision. Items still open are marked **[FLAG - OPEN]** and are the sections we return to first when we resume.

1. CORE CONCEPT & INSPIRATIONS

- A dream-themed game. Primary inspirations: Dungeon Dice Monsters and Final Fantasy Tactics Advance (GBA). We want to make a "dream version" of that.
- Kingdom Hearts: Chain of Memories (GBA) is also a key inspiration, especially for its card-draw combat.
- Design philosophy: complexity of interaction should arise from a small number of components. Embrace retro-style constraints as a source of creativity.
- Not a roguelike — no constant restarts. Saving and returning should feel like truly coming back to where you left off.

2. TARGET PLATFORMS

- Mac, desktop, and Steam.

3. ENGINE

- Godot. FINAL — locked in.

4. VISUAL LOOK

- 2D sprite art in a 3D world, viewed top-down at roughly a 65-degree angle.
- Screen blur at the top and bottom for a miniature/diorama look (reference: the Link's Awakening Switch remake).
- Top-down view, NOT isometric (isometric complicates environment art).
- Environment/ground: low-poly 3D models. Characters remain 2D sprites.
- Characters move and face in 8 directions.
- Sprites are traditional hand-drawn PNG sprites, drawn by Aidan himself. Placeholder text/colors are fine until each sprite is checked off.
- Sprite size: 32x32.

- Art style: hand-drawn, slightly chibi, slightly fantasy.
- Visual mix: low-poly 3D environments; 2D sprite characters, objects, animations and attacks; plus Godot particle effects (3D particles are fine). Mixed styles, but nothing too crazy — the game stays dedicated to fine pixel art.

5. CHARACTER ART & ANIMATION PIPELINE

- DECIDED (Oct 22, 2026): Smack Studio is SCRAPPED and is no longer part of the pipeline.
- Characters remain traditional hand-drawn 32x32 PNG sprites that move and face in 8 directions (see Section 4).
- AI is only an optional helper for base art (see Section 15, Asset Pipeline).
- **[Insert chosen method/tool for producing the 8 facing directions here.]**
- **[Insert chosen method/tool for producing animation frames here.]**
- **[Insert any automation plans for the chosen method here.]**
- **[FLAG - OPEN: how the 8 facing directions and animation frames get made, now that Smack Studio is scrapped.]**

6. CONTROLS

- Whole game uses 6 buttons total (not counting Start): four directions, plus Accept and Decline.
- Menus use directions + Accept/Decline.
- One button performs the gameplay action (Kirby-style single-button philosophy — controls can be simple).
- Tap, hold, and button+direction all count as distinct inputs within the 6-button scheme.

7. COMBAT & GAMEPLAY

- Real-time, top-down combat and gameplay.
- Card draw works like Chain of Memories: draw one card at a time, then either use it or shuffle it back. Some card effects draw more cards; some attack.
- Cards are drawn randomly during play.
- DECIDED: No reset. The deck depletes as cards are used, and used cards stay gone until the player reshuffles.
- Reshuffling is manual. The player chooses when to reshuffle and is briefly vulnerable while it happens.
- Reshuffle time scales with deck size: more cards to reshuffle means a longer wait.
- Base action: besides moving, the owl's one action is flapping his wings to create a gust of wind. He can flap while walking.
- The gust does weak damage plus knockback. It is a real attack from the start; cards are upgrades on top of it.

- Flapping is unlimited, with a short recovery between flaps (no stamina or charge meter).
- The gust is also a world tool: it blows aside loose pages, toppled books and other light obstacles.
- Aerial threats are signalled shadow-first: a shadow grows and sharpens on the ground before the creature drops into frame from above, out of camera view.

8. LOADOUT & CARD SYSTEM

- Loadout: choose one die and 10 cards.
- The die acts as a signature ability.
- Cards come in a variety of types.
- Card effects are varied but thoughtful — similar in gameplay effect to Vampire Survivors.
- Cards synergize with each other (e.g. a cooldown-reduction card makes cooldown cards more valuable).
- Card types established so far:
  - Prayer cards: the spell equivalent; add a weapon-style loadout slot.
  - Passive-effect cards.
  - One-time-use cards with cooldown timers.
- Loadout cards change the character's appearance — as small as a single shader texture or sprite.
- Passive card rule: passives are drawn and played like any other card, then stay active until the next reshuffle. A reshuffle clears all active passives.
- No cap on passives: they stack freely. Only a reshuffle clears them.
- Deck editing: always accessible from the pause menu via "Edit Deck". The entry is shown even when the player has no cards (there is just nothing to do there yet). When new cards or other relevant things unlock, an exclamation-mark notification badge appears on the menu entry.
- Card-style information displays are used throughout the UI.

9. CARD COLLECTION

- Cards are collectibles, found in level areas or obtained from drops.
- Cards come in tiers of rarity.
- Card lore: the owl is a magician trying to do magic in the dream. In this world magic is quantified and manifests as cards — that is why cards exist.
- Acquisition source 1, Memories: collectibles that let the owl remember a spell. He tries the remembered spell and it crystallises into a new card.
- Acquisition source 2, crystallised magic of other creatures: cards obtained from defeating enemies or from drops.
- **[FLAG - OPEN: specific card lore still to develop.]**

10. CHARACTERS

- Main character idea: an animal mage. Influences: Animal Crossing and Final Fantasy Tactics.
- DECIDED: the main character is an owl mage.
- Movement: hops and flutters, with small bird-like hops and short glides when dashing.
- The owl is a dream-wise, magical version of an owl (see Section 12 for who he really is).
- Companion: the finch, another bird, who asks the owl for help in act one. NOT an all-knowing guide or lore-dump character. The finch is just a person: not fully reassured themselves, catching the player up only incidentally, with their own uncertainty. The companion must not feel basic or cliché.
- Finch DECIDED: a yellow common finch. It leaves yellow feathers on the trail.
- After the rescue, the finch flies off.
- First antagonist: an American kestrel, reimagined as a demonic, nightmarish predator bird. It flees the tutorial fight instead of dying and becomes a recurring threat.
- Early enemies: bookworms (small worms poking out of the book-cliffs and grass) and a dream-twisted moth drawn to light.
- Creature design principle: not literal nature. Creatures are dream-twisted versions reflective of nature.

11. SOUNDTRACK & MUSIC SYSTEM

- Fully original soundtrack, composed by Aidan and his brother. Many tracks already written.
- Release plan: the album goes live on Spotify (and other streaming services via a distributor) at the same time as the game.
- In-game: a record collectible system (records replace the earlier CD idea). Players collect/unlock tracks as they play (found like cards).
- Unlocked tracks are played via an in-game music player with an information-based UI showing each track the player has collected.
- The soundtrack is INCLUDED with the game, not a separate purchase.
- Each record displays the track title and composer.
- Music player UI is card-style: each record is shown like a card, matching the game's card information displays.

12. STORY & WORLD

- Premise: the owl isn't really an owl. He is a wizard/mage of higher presence and sentience who finds himself in an owl's body in the dream world. He must fit the role of an owl: his eyes are especially valuable, and there is an expectation placed on him. He is caught up in a story and flustered ("why am I an owl and why am I here?"), the mood of a dream just beginning.
- Core motivation: the owl is trying to wake up. He feels utterly disconnected from reality, yet the dream world pulls on him hard. Analogy (not literal): waking up at the president's podium mid-speech with all eyes on you: "wait, I'm the president? I can't give a speech right now." That push-and-pull is his initial state.

- Story shape: the owl is a drop in the bucket next to the world he's in. The "I want to wake up" phase is only the beginning. He eventually gets over it, and the arc from there is far-reaching, in a world much bigger than he imagined. The world and story keep shifting in the audience's eyes too, overturning first impressions.
- Act one inciting situation: the owl is needed for something his true character would normally agree to help with. He genuinely wants to help, but is overwhelmed by "I'm an owl and this is a dream" and can't take it seriously yet. That conflict drives him forward.
- Act one hook: the kestrel is engaging with the finch, and the finch, curiously, asks the owl (itself a predator) for help. This is the first thing the world asks of him.
- World tone: the dream world doesn't beg for explanation. It is surreal, a bit silly and dreamy; players go with it rather than worrying about logistics.
- **[FLAG - OPEN: ending / win condition.]**
- **[FLAG - OPEN: how the world explains and builds itself to the owl.]**

13. OPENING & TUTORIAL

- Opening cutscene: after pressing Start, a Rondo of Blood-style intro cutscene with pixel artwork, original soundtrack, voiceover and story exposition. It also shows how the kestrel flies in.
- Cutscene skip: every cutscene can be skipped by holding the action button (X/A or platform equivalent) until a circular progress bar fills. The bottom-right corner shows the button icon with "hold to skip cutscene" text.
- Wake-up location: a library with grass growing between the shelves, a cosy but impossible space. The player gets control of the owl in an appealing environment that hooks them with curiosity about where they are and where to go.
- The snatch: almost immediately (the owl wakes, takes a few steps, all within the first minute) the kestrel drops in shadow-first and snatches the finch, carrying it off toward its nest. The owl watches from a distance while getting his bearings, and the finch and owl make eye contact.
- The tutorial IS the journey to reach the finch. Teaching happens through progressing toward the rescue, not before it. It must cover the card system and be as seamless and accessible as possible.
- Feather trail: the finch leaves yellow feathers as it is carried off. A yellow feather means "look for the finch."
- Stage 1, basic movement.
- Stage 2, basic overworld use and basic combat: the trail teaches the gust as a tool first (blowing aside loose pages, toppled books and obstacles), then a couple of easy critters near the end. The first enemies are bookworms.
- Stage 3, card interaction:
  - First card: the trail leads into an unlit stretch of stacks, an obstacle the gust can't solve. The owl instinctively tries a spell; in the dream all that can happen is the magic crystallises into a card that falls before him. Cards are first taught as problem-solvers.
  - The first card is a light card (passive): the owl glows, lighting the area around him.

  - Reshuffle lesson: where the dark stacks open into a lit area, the player is taught to reshuffle. Clearing the light here is harmless.
  - Second card: a dream-twisted moth, drawn to the owl's glow, follows him through the dark stacks and attacks once he steps into the lit area. Defeating it drops the second card.
  - Moth card: a one-time-use card with a cooldown. The owl releases a burst of the moth's wing dust that dazes/slows everything nearby. Longer cooldown than the gust; the effect lasts longer and has more range, but does less instant damage. Teaches the cooldown card type and crowd control.
  - Moth card name: Daze Dust.
- Tutorial finale: the feather trail leads to the kestrel's nest at the library's edge. The first real fight uses everything learned: gust, light card, Daze Dust and reshuffle. The kestrel flees instead of dying and becomes a recurring threat. The finch is rescued and flies off, which closes the linear opening.

14. GAME STRUCTURE: THE LIBRARY HUB

- Not a linear, beat-by-beat experience. The linear part ends with the tutorial; after that the game opens up.
- After the tutorial, the library becomes the hub. It reveals itself as the place that connects to the rest of the dream.
- Regions are entered through books: the owl opens a book on a lectern and is pulled into the world inside it.
- The owl's urge to wake up is the loose goal pulling him through regions, rather than a scripted chain of beats.
- Books become available three ways: (1) found while exploring and brought back to the library; (2) appearing in the library, never there before, when a story flag or progress condition is met; (3) sealed until the owl holds a certain card.
- Card checks also apply inside regions: if part of an area needs a certain card, that path stays locked until the card is acquired, so regions reward revisiting.
- Each book's appearance reflects the world inside it and its difficulty, so players can read the danger at a glance.
- The five regions are described in Section 16.
- After the rescue, the finch flies off (see Section 13).
- **[FLAG - OPEN: the story arc across the regions: what the owl gains or learns in each, and where Memories and records turn up.]**

15. ASSET PIPELINE

- Characters are drawn by Aidan himself (see Sections 4 and 5).
- SpriteCook (AI asset tool) is used for: placeholder sprites, so areas are playable before final art is done; card frames and card-style UI, including the deck editor and the record music player; and optional rough enemy concepts, which Aidan then redraws.

16. REGIONS

- Five regions, in no set order: Green Glacier, Forever Fever, Trash Island, Forgotten Toybox and White Space. Each is entered through its book in the library (see Section 14).
- Each region's official palette is the colour swatch on its hand-drawn concept page.
- **[Insert colour values here.]**

Green Glacier

- Setting: an ice island in a deep blue sea under a yellow sky, with the sun setting on the horizon.
- Green flash sunset: the green flash at sunset freezes time.
- Puzzles: ice block pushing puzzles.
- Environment: spikes/icicles that fall and drip upwards; breaking ice.
- Enemies: penguins that slide too fast to attack, which the green freeze lets the owl attack; projectile snowmen with pumpkin heads that explode upon death.

Forever Fever

- Setting: mesas rising out of orange, lava-like ground under a pink sky with a crying crescent moon; a rope bridge spans the mesas.
- Environment: exploding steam vents; moon tears fall from the sky and cause steam damage where they land.
- Enemies: moon masks; hell hounds, a skeleton hound with a snake wrapped around it. The snake does dash damage in four directions, the hound has a howl area-of-effect attack, and the hound must take damage for the snake to stop attacking.

Trash Island (renamed from Discarded Island)

- Setting: a trash-strewn island in a purple toxic sea, with pipes, a garbage can, an apple core, a banana peel and a dead tree.
- Environment: toxic sludge.
- Enemies: sludge enemies; a garbage bag snail with a leaf-blower dash attack; toxic plant enemies that fire projectiles (the concept also shows them asleep).
- Records (the music collectible) appear on this region's concept page.

Forgotten Toybox

- Setting: a dark room with a pink rug under a hanging lamp, scattered with toys.
- Stealth: walking into the lamp's light alerts enemies; avoiding the spotlight keeps the owl undetected.
- Puzzles: toy block puzzles and platforming.
- Environment: an unrolling ball of yarn hazard.
- Enemies: blanket ghosts; wind-up patchwork teddy bears (a small pink one and a large brown one holding a giant wind-up key).

White Space

- Entered through a white book that is always in the library.
- Can be visited many times. It is an enigma to the player: some cutscenes and story events happen there, and it sometimes becomes important to the story, but mostly it is just always there, strange and exciting to poke around in. Reference: the Hyperbolic Time Chamber.
- **[Insert White Space's look and contents here.]**

17. PRODUCTION / NEXT STEPS

- This document drives the build. Goal: make it studio-ready, thorough enough that a design team could read it for a week and share one vision.
- The build will be done largely via Claude Code.
- Approach: walk the game start to finish, one step at a time, filling gaps.

OPEN FLAGS — RESUME HERE

1. Character animation: how the 8 facing directions and animation frames get made (Section 5)
2. Story arc across the regions: what the owl gains or learns in each, and where Memories and records turn up (Sections 14 and 16). RESUME HERE.
3. Colour values for each region's palette (Section 16)
4. White Space's look, contents, and which story events and cutscenes happen there (Section 16)
5. Specific card lore (Section 9)
6. Ending / win condition (Section 12)
7. Final game title (the document still uses a working title)
8. How the world explains and builds itself to the owl (Section 12)

HOW WE WORK THIS DOCUMENT

- Decisions are made in conversation, tracked as we go, then batched into this document in one pass.
- Everything marked firm stays firm unless deliberately edited.
- **[FLAG - OPEN]** items are where we resume discussion, then branch out from there until the document is complete.